anomalies detected. Once again, everything was fine and Col Chawla reluctantly upgraded me back to SHAPE-1 and as I was told later, one of the few officers ever to be so upgraded. Ever since then, I have got myself tested regularly and have never hidden my health status. Health comes first. Even as the Army Commander, Eastern Command, when it was known that I was in the running for becoming Chief, I got myself comprehensively tested, including a CT angiography. I did the same before retirement and am proud to say that I retired in SHAPE-1.[2]

I got my first exposure to computerized war gaming during this tenure. The fledging Wargaming Development Centre (WARDEC) located in New Delhi had, in collaboration with a civilian software company, developed a rudimentary software. It was based on desert terrain, with a Company in defence and a Battalion in attack. The software needed to be test bedded and our unit was selected for it as the Battalion attacking and a Company from the other Battalion as the defence. It would be run under the supervision of the Brigade Commander, who was to act as the Control, directing the exercise, though it would be the system software that would give the outcome of each engagement. Before the game could be played, each side had to key in their detailed plans. The Control comprised the Commander, his staff and me. Keying in the plans was a laborious task, so rudimentary was the software. It would hang for no rhyme or reason, undoing hours of work, and rebooting the system itself was time-consuming. The last time the unit had been in the desert was in 1983, and except for the CO and me, no one had any knowledge of desert warfare. Quite naturally, Col Ghuman, the CO, asked me to take a few classes for the officers: what would be the enemy pattern of operations as a defender and what should be our own design of battle as

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation